

Long walk to freedom

QUESTIONS

Q1. Why was the May 10 an autumn day in South Africa?

Ans: On May 10, 1994 South Africa established its first non-racial government to taste the fruit of a long struggle against the white rule. The phrase "autumn day" has symbolical connotations. It symbolizes the "day of harvest" or the day of fruits. It is the fruit of freedom South Africa will taste after years of servitude.

Q2. At the beginning of his speech, Mandela mentions "an extra ordinary human disaster? What does he mean by this? What is the "glorious human achievement" he speaks of at the end?

Ans: The white rule for over hundreds of years and the discrimination on the basis of the colour of the skin has been called "an extraordinary human disaster". The political and social emancipation has been termed as "glorious human achievement".

Q3. What ideals does Nelson Mandela set out for the future of South Africa?

Ans: Mandela's dream of freeing his country from the apartheid practice finally came true. Nelson Mandela sets out a clear list of ideals for the future of South Africa. He envisages a South Africa without poverty, deprivation, suffering or discrimination of any kind.

Q4. Why did such a large number of international leaders attend the inauguration? What did it signify the triumph of?

Ans: The leaders from all over the world had come to honour the first democratic and nonracial government of South Africa. It was a common victory for justice, peace and human dignity. It signified a victory not only for the nation of South Africa but for the whole mankind.

Q5. What does Mandela mean when he says he is "simply the sum of all those African patriots" who had gone before him?

Ans: Mandela means to say that what South Africa had achieved was not a one-man job. The establishment of a non-racial government and Mandela's becoming the first black President would have never been possible without the sacrifices of all those people who had gone before him. The victory was not the result of Mandela's struggle only, but that of all the people who had sacrificed for the cause.

Q6. Would you agree that the depths of oppression create heights of character? How does Mandela illustrate this?

Ans: I agree with the statement of Nelson Mandela, we know that the greatest men have emerged in the most difficult times. When the going gets tough, the tough gets going, It proved true in the case of Mandela himself. With mounting oppression, Mandela's character scaled new heights.

Q7. What twin obligation does Mandela mention?

Ans: According to Nelson Mandela, everyman has twin obligations-the obligation towards one's family and kin and

the obligation towards one's people.

Q8. How did Mandela's understanding of freedom change with age and experience?

Ans: The young Mandela was growing up with his understanding of freedom also evolving. For a period, freedom meant to him the freedom to run in the fields. During his days as a student, freedom meant the freedom to read what he pleased and go where he liked. Then as a young man it meant the freedom to live a happy and dignified life. But then he realized that the real freedom meant the freedom for everyone who looked like him. All other freedoms were transitory.

Q9. How did Mandela's "hunger for freedom" change his life?

Ans. The hunger for freedom made Mandela a bold person. He became a man without fear. His struggle against the apartheid system forced him to become homeless and live a life of a monk. He was not less than a criminal in their eyes.